

Stuck in a moment

Price and piracy play havoc with the Indian gaming industry. Is there a way out, or is it doomed to be caught in a perennial rut of indifference and lethargy?

“It’s disconnected, fragmented and nascent.” After more than three years of living, breathing and writing about games, Sriram Sharma climbs onto his private mountain and passes judgment on his beloved pastime. Attention is to be duly paid. “Most people who play computer games, do so because they get it for free from someone else. A lot of piracy and bootlegging is going on.” Now is a good time to throw numbers around. The games software industry is expected to grow to a \$ 28.3 billion industry by 2004-05. Gaming budgets equal or surpass those of Hollywood movies. In terms of total revenue generated, the US gaming industry is actually bigger than Hollywood. Around 61 per cent of the total game players are above 18 years of age.

So much for the rest of the world. Come to India and notice the change in weather. Gaming here is a struggling activity: computers still cost a bundle; the latest consoles are only unofficially available; and online gaming is gasping on the shores of pathetic connectivity. To shed light on the gaming scene in this country, we spoke with gamers and game distributors. e-xpress Interactive Software and Milestone Interactive Software Ltd, are some firms that are the top players in our market that are fighting a desperate battle to increase awareness about games in general, and eliminate the demons of piracy.

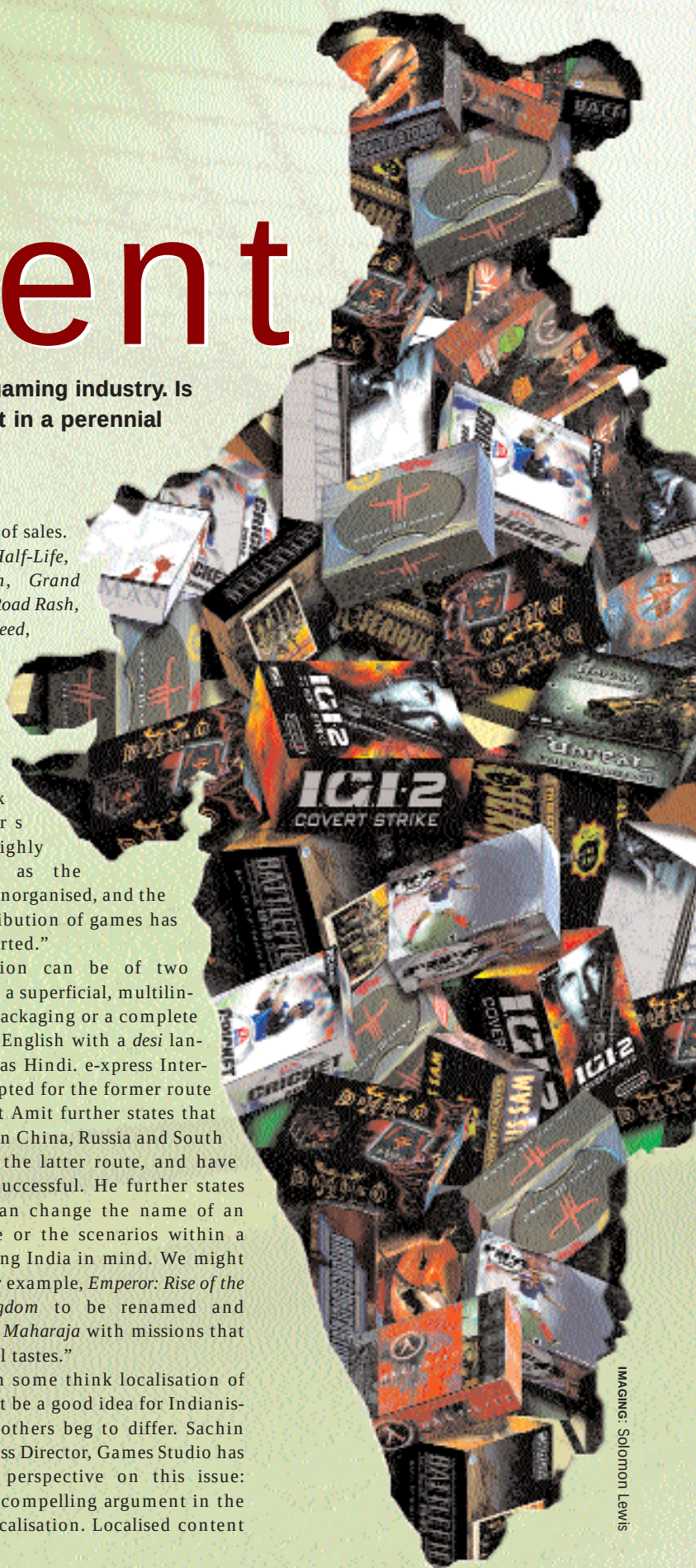
Do as the Romans do?

“The most popular game genres are action and sports”, says Amit Khemani, Head, Business Development at e-xpress. “Strategy games have also started picking

up in terms of sales. *Diablo*, *Half-Life*, *Serious Sam*, *Grand Theft Auto*, *Road Rash*, *Need for Speed*, *FIFA* and *Cricket* are very popular. As for quoting sales figures, I think numbers would be highly misleading, as the industry is unorganised, and the proper distribution of games has only just started.”

Localisation can be of two types, either a superficial, multilingual game packaging or a complete overhaul of English with a *desi* language such as Hindi. e-xpress Interactive has opted for the former route thus far. But Amit further states that the market in China, Russia and South Korea offer the latter route, and have been very successful. He further states that, “we can change the name of an entire game or the scenarios within a game, keeping India in mind. We might consider, for example, *Emperor: Rise of the Middle Kingdom* to be renamed and launched as *Maharaja* with missions that cater to local tastes.”

Although some think localisation of games might be a good idea for Indianising games, others beg to differ. Sachin Naik, Business Director, Games Studio has a different perspective on this issue: “There’s no compelling argument in the favour of localisation. Localised content



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